CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

SPEECH THERAPIST IN THE AI ERA

Speech, language, swallowing — the therapist for the most human functions there are.

★ TL;DR — Median $97,870 with +17% growth and ~12,500 openings a year (BLS), on a 4+ year path: bachelor's, a 2-year accredited master's, the Praxis exam, a supervised clinical fellowship and a state licence — required in all states. The catch: the largest employer, schools (39% of jobs), pays $83,120 — know your setting's number before you borrow. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

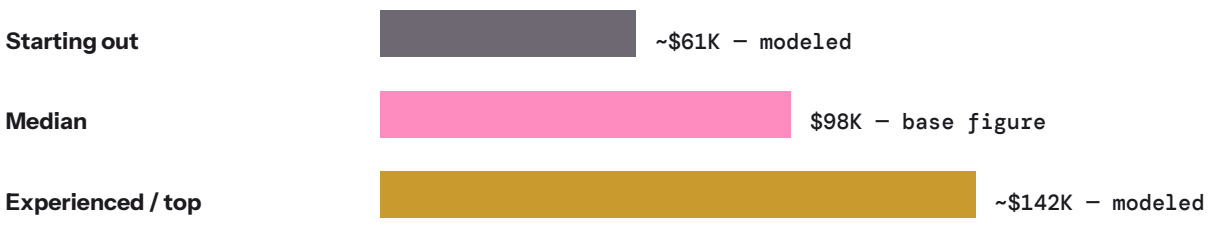
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$98K · TRAINING 4+ years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- +17% growth and ~12,500 openings a year: twenty times the annual door of audiology, the sister field that failed this batch's bar — on half the training time.
- The licence ladder is the moat: accredited master's → Praxis exam → provisional licence → 36-week supervised fellowship → ASHA CCC-SLP and full state licence. ASHA's own position: AI cannot replace the clinician, who stays ethically accountable for every tool used.
- AI assists the counting, not the clinic: LLM scoring of language samples runs close to the standard software, but generic speech recognition auto-corrects disordered speech — off-the-shelf error rates on disordered child speech run near 50% at the phoneme level, exactly where the diagnosis lives.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Speech Therapist is a ~$98K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars

are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A SPEECH THERAPIST ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Evaluate speech, language, voice and swallowing disorders
- ✓ Run therapy sessions: articulation, language building, fluency, cognitive-communication
- ✓ Do swallowing studies and diet recommendations with the medical team
- ✓ Write IEPs and care plans; coach families and teachers on strategies

Think: a translator between a person and the world — rebuilding the channel everyone else takes for granted.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Language-sample counting and scoring assistance, practice-material generation, screening support and between-session practice apps sold THROUGH clinicians. Whisper-class speech recognition 'corrects' disordered speech, destroying the very signal being assessed.	Diagnosing why communication broke down in this particular brain, and adapting therapy minute by minute to a frustrated child or patient.

⚠ **Price the setting, not the headline: hospitals pay $103,690 and nursing/residential care $109,660, while schools — 39% of all jobs — pay $83,120 with the biggest caseloads and the IEP paperwork mountains. The pipeline is long and specific; negotiate caseload and mentorship, not just salary.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ School-calendar schedules exist in this profession ✓ One-on-one work with visible breakthroughs ✓ Settings: schools, hospitals, private practice, teletherapy	✗ Huge school caseloads and IEP paperwork mountains ✗ Graduate debt against a solid-but-not-huge median ✗ Progress can be slow; patience is a job requirement

Good fit? Linguistic, observant and endlessly patient — you find communication itself fascinating.
Bad fit? You want quick credentials or work without children and paperwork.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — COMMUNICATION SCIENCES DEGREE, THEN MASTER'S	DOOR B — SLPA FIRST
Bachelor's in communication sciences and disorders (or prerequisites alongside another degree), then an accredited master's in speech-language pathology with practicum, the national exam, a clinical fellowship and your state license.	Work as a speech-language pathology assistant under supervision while completing the graduate path. It pays less and scopes narrower, but it banks real clinical experience and income.

Smart move: Get observation hours in both a school and a medical setting before grad school — your fellowship and first-job choices get much smarter.
Where you land after: Speech therapist → specialty niches (voice, swallowing, AAC), school leadership, hospital teams — or a private practice of your own.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
MAP THE	BUILD THE	LOG OBSERVATION	COMPLETE THE	EXAM AND	PICK YOUR

STEP 1 — Map the graduate path

FREE · TODAY

- List accredited master's programs, prerequisites and practicum structure.
- Read your state's SLP license requirements, including the fellowship year.

STEP 2 — Build the undergraduate base

YEARS · FOUNDATION

- Degree or coursework in communication sciences: linguistics, anatomy, development.
- GPA matters — programs are competitive.

STEP 3 — Log observation hours

WEEKS

- Observe licensed SLPs in school and medical settings.
- Volunteer with stroke groups or children's programs for real exposure.

STEP 4 — Complete the master's + fellowship

GRADUATE · 2 YEARS + FELLOWSHIP

- Graduate coursework and 400 supervised practicum clock hours across populations.
- Then the 36-week (1,260-hour) clinical fellowship under a CCC-SLP mentor, on a provisional licence.

STEP 5 — Exam and state license

EXAM FEE · AFTER FELLOWSHIP

- Pass the national Praxis exam for speech-language pathology.
- Receive your full state license and ASHA CCC-SLP — required before independent practice.

STEP 6 — Pick your first setting deliberately

JOB HUNT · 2-6 WEEKS

- Schools offer calendars at $83,120; medical settings pay $98–110K with more acuity. Both are valid first doors — chosen, not defaulted.
- Negotiate caseload and mentorship, not just salary.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: map accredited master's programs, prerequisites and your state license rules.
- □ Days 1–30: start prerequisite gaps; contact SLPs about observation hours.
- □ Days 31–60: observation hours underway in one setting; application timeline set.
- □ Days 61–90: second-setting observation done; target programs chosen with debt math done.
- □ Day 90: the graduate pipeline is planned and moving — hours, prereqs and schools all lined up.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **EVERY VOICE COUNTS.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.